

Abdominal exercises

Strong abdominal muscles will help you carry the weight of your baby and assist you during labor and birth. Try to do the exercises below regularly, but always listen to your body and rest when you need to.

After the first trimester, try to avoid exercises that require you to lie flat on your back. The reason for this is that when you lie on your back, your enlarged uterus presses on one of your major blood vessels, reducing the amount of blood pumped around the body and to the baby. However, the good news is you can strengthen abdominal muscles without lying on your back by using gravity and your body to strengthen and tone the torso.

In pregnancy, you can tone your abdomen with exercises where you adopt an all-fours position or an upright sitting position. Try to do the exercises below around 2–3 times a week.

Benefits of abdominal exercises Strong abdominal muscles enable your body to work more efficiently in labor. They also help support the weight of the baby, which takes pressure off the spine, reducing the likelihood of backaches. In addition, keeping your abdominal muscles strong means that you may be less likely to get a condition called diastasis recti, in which the abdominal wall muscles separate, often following childbirth, making it harder to regain your figure.



The sling Get down on all fours with your hands on the floor, feet apart, and arms straight. Keep your back flat in a neutral position. Imagine the abdominal muscles as a sling holding your baby. Take a deep breath, then slowly pull your abdominal muscles (the sling) in toward your back, pulling the baby closer to you, and gently release, returning to the starting position. Try to do 20 repetitions. Remember to breathe while doing this exercise, breathing in to start and breathing out as you pull in your belly.